

D680

Elementary Social Studies Curriculum

Armored Drill

8 concepts · 12 items · 4 transfer items

What this is. Every concept in this course's public description, re-asked with more disguise than a practice test uses. Each stem carries facts that do not decide it. Every wrong answer is a named trap.

Source. Scope from the course's public description in the WGU Institutional Catalog (September 2026); items written from the field's standard body of knowledge. No WGU assessment item, course material or proprietary content is used or reproduced. Not affiliated with or endorsed by Western Governors University.

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How to run it

Paper first. Pencil. One pass, no notes, a timer if you want the pressure.

1. **Before you read the options**, fill the strip under the item: the target word (what is actually being asked), and the one fact in the stem that decides it.
2. **Principle before arithmetic**. Name the rule, then compute.
3. **Camouflage**. Most of every stem does not matter. Ask: which single fact decides this?
4. **Inverse pairs are the bait**. If two options are opposites, one of them is the trap built for you.
5. **Mark sure, unsure or guess** honestly. Sure-and-wrong is the most valuable miss on the page — it is a wrong mental model.
6. **Absolutes** (always, never, guarantee) are usually wrong. And recognizing an answer is not the same as owning it.
7. Items with a **heavy black bar** on the left are **transfer items**: the same principle, reversed or solved for a different variable.
8. Stop at the STOP page. Then grade, fill the triage grid, and tally the traps you fell for. The biggest tally is what you drill next.

The strip, filled in, looks like this:

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	_____	

Items

1.

A second-grade class in a school with a large garden studies how a loaf of bread gets from a wheat farm to a store and who pays whom along the way. The teacher plans to invite a parent who drives a delivery truck. Which NCSS theme does the lesson mainly address?

- A. Science, Technology, and Society.
- B. Individuals, Groups, and Institutions.
- C. Production, Distribution, and Consumption.
- D. People, Places, and Environments.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

2. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

A teacher wants a lesson for the NCSS theme Power, Authority, and Governance. Which lesson fits?

- A. Students map where their families' foods are grown.
- B. Students describe holidays their families celebrate.
- C. Students trace how their town's main street changed from 1900 to today.
- D. Students compare how a class rule and a city law are made and who enforces each.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

3.

Fourth graders are investigating whether their state should build a new dam. Having read a news article, a government report, and a letter from a farm group, they now rank each source by who wrote it and what evidence it offers. The unit culminates in a family night. Which Inquiry Arc dimension are students in?

- A. Dimension 3: Evaluating sources and using evidence.
- B. Dimension 2: Applying disciplinary concepts and tools.
- C. Dimension 1: Developing questions and planning inquiries.
- D. Dimension 4: Communicating conclusions and taking informed action.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

4.

A first-grade team at a school that recently adopted new report cards is mapping social studies content for the year under the traditional expanding-communities sequence. Which focus fits first grade?

- A. Our state's regions and government.
- B. Families, past and present.
- C. World history only, because young students need a global view first.
- D. The history of the United States.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

5.

A third-grade teacher found a popular pioneer-life craft kit online that students loved last year. The district's standard asks students to explain how people in the past met their needs differently than people do today. Using backward design, what should the teacher do first?

- A. Pick the activities first, then write a test at the end.
- B. Decide what students should understand from the standard, then design the evidence that will show it.
- C. Write a test on pioneer vocabulary.
- D. Build the unit around the craft kit, then find a matching standard.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

6.

A student's report says her grandmother's town, founded by fur traders, is "about two hours north of the big lake, just past the state park." The report has a hand-drawn cover. Which geography theme does that phrase show?

- A. Movement.
- B. Place.
- C. Absolute location.
- D. Relative location.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

7. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

Which statement is an example of human-environment interaction?

- A.** The Midwest is known for its corn belt.
- B.** Many families moved west to find work.
- C.** Farmers built terraces into the hillside to grow rice.
- D.** The city is at 40° N, 75° W.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

8.

A class with an excellent attendance record earned 40 minutes of free time. Students ranked three choices: extra recess first, a movie second, and art centers third. They chose extra recess. What is the opportunity cost?

- A.** Extra recess.
- B.** The movie.
- C.** The movie and the art centers.
- D.** 40 minutes.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

9. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

A student with \$10 buys a book instead of a toy she wanted almost as much. The toy is the opportunity cost. What made a choice necessary in the first place?

- A.** Opportunity cost — the toy forced the choice.
- B.** The \$10, which is the cost of both items.
- C.** Supply and demand in the store.
- D.** Scarcity — she had more wants than her \$10 could cover.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

10.

Fifth graders read that their state's legislature, which meets in a century-old stone capitol, passed a bill requiring bike helmets for children. The governor then signed it. Which branch made the law?

- A.** The executive branch, because the governor signed it.
- B.** The judicial branch.
- C.** The legislative branch.
- D.** The capitol building's historical commission.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

11. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

A court rules that a city's new rule breaks the state constitution. Which check does this show?

- A.** The judicial branch checking the legislative branch.
- B.** Courts making a new law.
- C.** The executive branch vetoing a bill.
- D.** The legislative branch checking the judicial branch.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	_____	

12.

A fourth-grade teacher with a 90-minute literacy block uses a nonfiction article about the state's first settlers to teach main idea. The only assessment is a main-idea quiz. The principal praised the lesson's engagement. What is the problem from a social studies curriculum view?

- A.** No social studies objective is taught or assessed, so the topic is only a backdrop for reading.
- B.** Nothing, because the principal praised it.
- C.** Social studies should never be combined with reading.
- D.** The lesson is too long; it should fit a 45-minute block.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	_____	

STOP

Answers and dissection follow. Finish every item and every strip first.

Key and dissection

Struck-through text is the camouflage: facts that do not decide the item.

1. Answer C Concept 1

A second-grade class ~~in a school with a large garden~~ studies how a loaf of bread gets from a wheat farm to a store and who pays whom along the way. ~~The teacher plans to invite a parent who drives a delivery truck.~~ Which NCSS theme does the lesson mainly address?

Target word: which NCSS theme **Decides:** The path from producer to consumer and the payments — economics.

A	Confusion set	Would fit a lesson on how machines changed farming, not on buying and selling.
B	Camouflage	Keys on the visiting parent; a guest speaker does not set the theme.
C	Correct	How goods are made, moved, and bought is this economics strand.
D	Adjacent category	Farms are places, but the focus is the economic chain, not geography.

2. Answer D Concept 1 • transfer

A teacher wants a lesson for the NCSS theme Power, Authority, and Governance. Which lesson fits?

Target word: choose the lesson from the theme — reverse of naming the theme **Decides:** The theme is about how people create and change authority and rules.

A	Adjacent category	Geography and trade, not governance.
B	Inverted operation	Culture — a different strand entirely.
C	Confusion set	Time, Continuity, and Change.
D	Correct	Who holds authority and how rules are made — the heart of this theme.

3. Answer A Concept 2

Fourth graders are investigating whether their state should build a new dam. Having read a news article, a government report, and a letter from a farm group, they now rank each source by who wrote it and what evidence it offers. ~~The unit culminates in a family night.~~ Which Inquiry Arc dimension are students in?

Target word: which C3 dimension **Decides:** Judging sources and weighing evidence is Dimension 3.

A	Correct	Ranking sources by author and evidence is source evaluation.
B	Adjacent category	Uses geography or civics concepts; the step described is about the sources themselves.
C	Inverted operation	Question-building comes before gathering and judging sources.
D	Camouflage	Keys on the family night, which is later; ranking sources is not communicating.

4. Answer B Concept 3

A first-grade team ~~at a school that recently adopted new report cards~~ is mapping social studies content for the year under the traditional expanding-communities sequence. Which focus fits first grade?

Target word: grade-level scope **Decides:** First grade traditionally studies families.

A	Adjacent category	State studies are traditionally grade 4.
B	Correct	Self/school (K), family (1), neighborhood/community (2–3), state (4), nation (5).
C	Absolute language	Reverses the sequence, which builds outward from the familiar.
D	Inverted operation	The nation is the far end of the sequence (grade 5).

5. Answer B Concept 4

A third-grade teacher found a popular pioneer-life craft kit online ~~that students loved last year~~. The district's standard asks students to explain how people in the past met their needs differently than people do today. Using backward design, what should the teacher do first?

Target word: first step of planning **Decides:** Backward design starts from the standard and the understanding it names.

A	Inverted operation	Reverses the order of backward design.
B	Correct	Desired results come first, then assessment, then activities.
C	Dropped element	Skips the understanding the standard names (comparing past and present).
D	Camouflage	Chases the popular kit; that is activity-first planning.

6. Answer D Concept 5

A student's report says her grandmother's town, ~~founded by fur traders~~, is "about two hours north of the big lake, just past the state park." ~~The report has a hand-drawn cover.~~ Which geography theme does that phrase show?

Target word: which theme of geography **Decides:** Position described in relation to other places.

A	Camouflage	Keys on the fur-trader history; the phrase describes position, not the flow of people or goods.
B	Adjacent category	Place describes what an area is like (its features), not where it is.
C	Confusion set	That would be coordinates or an exact address.
D	Correct	Describes where it is compared with landmarks.

7. Answer C Concept 5 • transfer

Which statement is an example of human-environment interaction?

Target word: choose the example for a theme **Decides:** People changing, adapting to, or depending on the environment.

A	Dropped element	Region — describes an area but drops the human change to the land.
B	Adjacent category	Movement of people.
C	Correct	People modify the land to meet needs.
D	Confusion set	Absolute location.

8. Answer B Concept 6

A class ~~with an excellent attendance record~~ earned 40 minutes of free time. Students ranked three choices: extra recess first, a movie second, and art centers third. They chose extra recess. What is the opportunity cost?

Target word: opportunity cost of the choice **Decides:** Only the next-best alternative counts.

A	Inverted operation	That is what they chose, not what they gave up.
B	Correct	The movie was the second choice — the next-best alternative given up.
C	Dropped element	Drops the "single next-best" part; opportunity cost is not every option.
D	Wrong stem number	The time budget (the scarce resource), not the alternative forgone.

9. Answer D Concept 6 • transfer

A student with \$10 buys a book instead of a toy she wanted almost as much. The toy is the opportunity cost. What made a choice necessary in the first place?

Target word: the cause of the choice — reverse from cost back to scarcity **Decides:** Limited money versus more wants.

A	Inverted operation	Opportunity cost results from the choice; scarcity causes it.
B	Wrong stem number	Her budget, not the reason a choice exists.
C	Adjacent category	Sets prices, not whether she must choose.
D	Correct	Limited resources force a choice; opportunity cost follows.

10. Answer C Concept 7

Fifth graders read that their state's legislature, ~~which meets in a century-old stone capitol~~, passed a bill requiring bike helmets for children. The governor then signed it. Which branch made the law?

Target word: which branch makes law **Decides:** Passing a bill is legislative work.

A	Confusion set	The executive approves and enforces; the legislature makes the law.
B	Adjacent category	Courts interpret laws, not pass them.
C	Correct	Legislatures make laws; signing completes the process.
D	Camouflage	Chases the building detail; it plays no role in lawmaking.

11. Answer A Concept 7 • transfer

A court rules that a city's new rule breaks the state constitution. Which check does this show?

Target word: name the check from the action **Decides:** Courts interpret laws against the constitution.

A	Correct	Judicial review limits laws that conflict with the constitution.
B	Adjacent category	Courts interpret; they do not legislate.
C	Confusion set	A veto is a different check by a different branch.
D	Inverted operation	Reverses who is checking whom.

12. Answer A Concept 8

A fourth-grade teacher with a 90-minute literacy block uses a nonfiction article about the state's first settlers to teach main idea. The only assessment is a main-idea quiz. ~~The principal praised the lesson's engagement.~~ What is the problem from a social studies curriculum view?

Target word: what integration is missing **Decides:** No social studies standard is taught or assessed.

A	Correct	True integration keeps a social studies standard and checks it.
B	Camouflage	Engagement does not show the social studies standard was met.
C	Absolute language	Integration is valuable when both subjects' goals are kept.
D	Wrong stem number	The 90 minutes is not the problem.

Triage grid

Write each item number in the box it belongs to.

	Right	Wrong
Sure	Owned.	Concept inversion — top priority. A wrong mental model; it survives rewording.
Unsure / guess	Recognition, not mastery. Re-drill with the transfer.	Not learned yet.

Trap tally

For every miss, find the letter you chose in the key and tally its trap. The biggest number is the pattern to drill.

Trap	What it does	In this drill	Your misses
Dropped element	Leaves out a required term or step.	3	
Wrong stem number	A figure copied from the prompt that is not the answer.	3	
Adjacent category	The right idea in the wrong bucket.	9	
Inverted operation	Direction flipped: add/subtract, cause/effect, higher/lower.	7	
Absolute language	Always, never, guarantee — where judgment applies.	2	
Confusion set	Every option is real; the test is exact role-matching.	6	
Camouflage	Answers a stem fact that was never the question.	6	

Anchor rows — the concept list

One row per concept: the rule to lock in, the trap that catches people, and the tell in the question that signals it.

#	Concept	Rule	Trap	Tell
1	The NCSS thematic strands	The ten NCSS themes (such as Culture; Time, Continuity, and Change; People, Places, and Environments; Power, Authority, and Governance; Production, Distribution, and Consumption) organize content across the disciplines.	Labeling a lesson by its topic or activity instead of the big idea it develops.	“Which NCSS theme does this lesson address?”
2	The C3 Inquiry Arc	The C3 Framework’s four dimensions run in order: develop questions and plan; apply disciplinary concepts and tools; evaluate sources and use evidence; communicate conclusions and take informed action.	Mixing up the dimensions or starting with conclusions.	“Which dimension of the Inquiry Arc is this step?”
3	Expanding communities sequence	The traditional K-5 sequence widens outward: self and school, family, neighborhood, community, state, nation, then world.	Assuming young children should start with the nation or world.	A grade level paired with a scope of study.
4	Backward design and standards alignment	Plan by starting with the standard and desired understanding, then decide the assessment evidence, and only then choose activities.	Choosing a fun activity first and matching a standard afterward.	“What should the teacher do first when planning the unit?”
5	Five themes of geography	Location (absolute or relative), place, human-environment interaction, movement, and region each ask a different question about Earth.	Confusing absolute location (coordinates, address) with relative location (near a landmark), or place with location.	A description of where something is, what it is like, or how people change it.
6	Scarcity and opportunity cost	Scarcity forces choices; opportunity cost is the value of the single next-best alternative given up.	Adding up all the alternatives or counting the chosen item as the cost.	A choice among several options with limited money or time.
7	Branches of government	The legislative branch makes laws, the executive carries them out, and the judicial branch interprets them; each checks the others.	Assigning law-making to the president or governor.	An official or body and the job it performs.
8	Integration that keeps social studies objectives	Integrating social studies with reading or math works only when a social studies standard is still taught and assessed.	A reading passage on a historical topic counted as social studies instruction.	An integrated lesson whose only assessment is a literacy skill.

Course scope (public description): Elementary Social Studies Curriculum is a thorough course tailored for educators looking to develop and implement a rich, engaging social studies curriculum for elementary-aged students. This course offers an in-depth examination of the key concepts and themes essential for teaching social studies effectively at the elementary level. Emphasizing a multidisciplinary approach, the curriculum covers

history, geography, civics, economics, and culture, ensuring a well-rounded understanding of the subject. Additionally, it addresses the incorporation of standards into curriculum planning and the promotion of civic engagement among young learners. Through a blend of theoretical knowledge, this course aims to prepare educators with the tools necessary to align instructional strategies with social studies standards in meaningful ways.